he used to build the party office and his son's residence. Tripathi has secured conditional bail, effective at a later date.

On the evening of March 10, after the ED sleuths had left, Baghel told the media that the agency had found Rs 33 lakh in cash, which they took with them. He stated that his family owns 140 acres of land, where they practise modern agriculture and that the money would be accounted for. He then added a twist, claiming the ED had found a pen drive containing incriminating conversations between BJP ex-CM Raman Singh's son-in-law, Dr Punit Gupta, and one Manturam. He said the ED had confiscated other evidence of corruption related to Raman, but did not take those papers.

The CBI's case in the Mahadev scam involves probing the payment of protection money to sustain the racket. The Mahadev app, an online betting platform, has been operational for several years, its promoters being Saurabh Chandrakar and Ravi Uppal, originally from Bhilai town but now reportedly based in Dubai. The CBI claims it has incriminating digital and documentary evidence linking government and public servants to the payment of protection money in what is estimated to be a Rs 6,000 crore scam. "Just when Bhupesh Baghel was appointed general secretary in charge of Punjab and took a meeting there, the ED landed up. Two weeks later, when he raised the issue of corruption in ration supply in the assembly, the CBI landed up. This shows the BJP's frustration," says Congress spokesperson Sushil Anand Shukla.

Investigative agencies are covering a gamut of allegations against leaders and officials from the previous Congress regime. "I have listed the money trail in the liquor scam and the Mahadev betting racket, besides also sending detailed letters of the modus operandi in scams pertaining to PSC recruitment, medical supplies and the DMF (District Mineral Foundation) matter," says senior lawyer and BJP state office in-charge Naresh Gupta. "The recoveries from the search are the subject matter of investigation. (They are) being analysed and the findings will be the basis for further questioning," says special public prosecutor of the ED, Saurabh Pandey. With the powder dry on both sides, the political storm is far from over. ■

WEST BENGAL

THE CHARM OFFENSIVE

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

Mamata Banerjee arrived in London on March 23, her flight 10 hours behind schedule. Undeterred, the West Bengal chief minister was in Hyde Park next morning, fitting in her signature morning exercises before embarking on her packed six-day itinerary. She met business leaders to pitch her state as an investment destination, pushed for the revival of a Kolkata-London direct flight and attended a reception hosted by India's high commissioner. The centrepiece of her visit was a speech at Oxford's Kellogg College. It was not the usual pugnacity on show. Instead, a softer elocution flowed—keywords like "women-focused initiatives", and its Bengal exemplar, "Kanyashree".

For her supporters, it was a triumphant tour. A Trinamool Congress (TMC) MLA, eager to dramatise its significance, compared it to Sourav Ganguly's famous celebration at Lord's after India's 2002 NatWest Trophy win. The leader, who wished to remain anonymous, claimed that, for many Bengalis, Didi's visit—where she supposedly "won the hearts of the people she encountered"—would be as iconic an image of a Bengali "creating history" as that of an exultant Ganguly waving his jersey above his head.

That may have actually misrepresented the nature of her win. The visit largely hit the right chords, barring a few hiccups. It allowed Mamata to position herself as a formidable national figure in Indian politics, just as state elections loom next year. Kunal Ghosh, a journalist-turned-TMC leader who accompanied her, claimed the trip was a success. "Industrialists from Bengal who were part of our delegation, as well as representatives of British companies with operations in the state, acknowledged that the problem of labour unrest has been eliminated—there are no lost man-days. Most importantly, the chief minister is just a WhatsApp message away, and if her office is informed of an issue, they ensure swift resolution."

A standout moment was Mamata's reception at the Indian high commission. Earlier, the Union ministry of

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>
> **KUNAL GHOSH**
> TMC leader and journalist